

****Big Brother in Space: The Spy Satellites of a US Startup****

Intervention by Guido Scorza, member of the Italian Data Protection Authority
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It was not enough to have hundreds of millions of differently intelligent electronic eyes that now scrutinize us everywhere from the ground, making it increasingly difficult to claim a true right to privacy and, with it, the cluster of fundamental rights and freedoms of which we are proud defenders. Now, reading the news bouncing from the columns of the New York Times, we must also begin to worry about thousands of equally indiscreet electronic eyes that could soon peek into the sky, right between one star and another. The American startup Albedo Space has, in fact, raised 100 million dollars to design and build a fleet of satellites that, starting in 2025, will scrutinize the world, including people, twenty-four hours a day, from space at a distance from the Earth lower than that of the orbits already traversed by thousands of other satellites.

And from that height, it seems, it will be possible – at least technologically – to crumble the wall of privacy because little or nothing will remain indistinguishable. License plate numbers, faces of individuals, and probably even smaller details. The safest remedy for the defense of our privacy may become the good old umbrella, to be used rigorously even on sunny days!

Jokes aside – also because the scenario is unsettling and takes away the desire to laugh – although the risk of mass surveillance from space has existed for some time, what worries about this new possible space adventure is the likely opening of access to the new satellites to an enormously wider public and, probably, the progressive decrease in costs at least directly proportional to the increase in the supply of services and solutions useful for observing from above what happens on Earth.

****The Indiscreet Eye of Albedo Space Satellites****

Needless to say – but only because it is obvious – that the same technological evolution, inexorably, poses and will pose increasingly complicated challenges for the defense of privacy against the risk of invasions from space. Albedo Space, in fact, aims to acquire and distribute optical images with a resolution such that it can visualize people, places, and objects with a precision superior to that currently possible with the technologies in circulation.

Topher Haddad, CEO of Albedo Space, has already put his hands up and tried to reassure the world and privacy advocates, stating in a recent interview that "We are deeply aware of the implications for privacy" and reassuring everyone that the company will evaluate new clients on a case-by-case basis, will adopt appropriate security measures to prevent potential abuses, and will ensure that the terms and conditions of contracts provide for punitive measures for violations of company policies.

****In the Center, the CEO of Albedo Space****

Will that be enough? For heaven's sake, as usual, let us not forget that the expected benefits from this new generation of satellites and the services it will enable are enormous and concern a series of strategic areas for the future of humanity: security, defense, climate emergencies, natural disasters, just to name a few.

However, at the same time, it is undeniable that the launch of the new satellites, their activation, and the provision of related services to public and private clients curious to scrutinize the world from the stars pose enormous challenges in terms of personal data protection and privacy that we must prepare to face, working, first and foremost, on the design of the devices in question and, therefore, on the characteristics of the services that will be provided by Albedo Space and the many other companies that will likely soon join them in the race.

It is hard to think that we will return to gazing at the stars without the feeling of being observed, and this, in itself, represents a huge limitation on people's freedom that we cannot and will not be able to ignore.